Jodo Shiai and Shinpan Regulations

Jodo Shiai and Shinpan — Detailed Rules

Attachment 1: Guidelines for Holding and Judging Jodo Matches

Attachment 2: Amendments to the Jodo Shiai and Shinpan Regulations and Key Operational Considerations

June 2, 2023

All Japan Kendo Federation

Translators' Notes

The All Japan Kendo Federation (全日本剣道連盟; AJKF) published the *Jodo Shiai and Shinpan Regulations* and its companion documents to govern the conduct of jodo matches and judging at tournaments. No official English translation of these documents is currently available to the international jodo community. This translation was undertaken for one purpose: to support the growth and spread of jodo among English-speaking practitioners.

This is an unofficial translation. It has not been authorized or endorsed by the All Japan Kendo Federation, which holds all rights to the original Japanese documents. It is offered to the community for non-commercial educational use only. **The original Japanese text is the sole authoritative document.** In all matters of rule interpretation and official adjudication, the Japanese source supersedes this translation.

Readers will notice that many Japanese terms have been retained in romanized form rather than replaced with English equivalents. This is a deliberate choice: terms such as *Embu*, *Maai*, *Reiho*, *Zanshin* carry cultural and technical meaning that no English word fully captures, and using the romaji preserves that meaning for readers who already know them while providing a foothold for those who do not. Where a gloss aids comprehension, it is given in parentheses on first use within each section — for example, *Reiho* (Etiquette) or *Gogi* (Deliberation) — and the term then appears unglossed. A complete glossary, with Japanese, romaji, English equivalent, and usage notes, is included as an appendix.

All errors in this translation are the responsibility of the translators alone and should not be attributed to any federation or organization. Readers who identify errors or have questions about meaning are encouraged to consult the original Japanese source.

Tom Groendal served as primary translator and holds final responsibility for all translation decisions. **Jeff Broderick** reviewed the translation for fluency and accuracy against the Japanese source.

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Rules for Jodo Shiai and Shinpan hereinafter referred to as "the Rules"	Jodo Shiai and Shinpan — Detailed Rules hereinafter referred to as "the Detailed Rules"
(Purpose of These Regulations) Article 1 — These Regulations govern jodo matches held under the auspices of the All Japan Kendo Federation. Their purpose is to ensure that matches are conducted with integrity and openness, and that judging is carried out with propriety and impartiality, in accordance with the principles of the jo. Part 1 — Matches Chapter 1 — General Provisions (Courts)	
Article 2 — Court standards are as follows; the floor should be wooden, in principle. 1. The court is as shown in Figure 1. 2. Starting line length and placement are set out in the Detailed Rules. (Equipment)	Detailed Rule 1 — Rule 2 (Courts) is as follows. 1. The starting lines are 5 to 10 cm (2 to 4 in) wide, in two colors: red and white. 2. Starting line length, placement, and other court dimensions are as shown in Figure 1.
Article 3 — The equipment used is the Jo and the Tachi (Bokuto); specifications are set out in the Detailed Rules.	Detailed Rule 2 — Rule 3 (Equipment) is as follows. 1. The jo is 128 cm (50.4 in) long and 2.4 cm

Rules	Detailed Rules
(Attire)	(0.94 in) in diameter; the material is a round white oak staff. 2. The tachi is 101.5 cm (40.0 in) overall, with a handle of 24.2 cm (9.5 in) and a curve of 1.5 cm (0.6 in); it has a leather tsuba, and the material is white oak (bokuto).
Article 4 — The uniform is kendo gi and hakama.	Detailed Rule 3 — Competitors' Nafuda (Name Badge) follows Figure 3 and is worn on the left chest. Detailed Rule 4 — Shinpan-ki (Judge's Flag) and other item specifications are as shown in Figure 4. Article 5 — Supportive braces or sleeves and similar items may be worn only when medically necessary, provided they are not unsightly. Article 6 — Competitors' entry and exit from the court, and their performance of Reiho (Etiquette), follow the procedures prescribed by the tournament.

Rules	Detailed Rules
Chapter 2 — Matches Section 1 — Match Provisions (Competitor Pairing) Article 5 — Competitors should be paired in groups of two from the same dan grade, in principle. (Matches) Article 6 — Matches take the form of a Tournament Bracket or Round-Robin. (Individual Match) Article 7 — An Individual Match is conducted by rank group or as an open division. Competitors perform the Shitei-waza (designated techniques) in the prescribed order, alternating roles as Shi and Uchi (*Shi-Uchi Kotai*), and demonstrate their Embu. The competitor with the greater flag count, as determined by the judges, wins. (Team Match) Article 8 — Team matches are decided by the following methods, as well as any additional methods prescribed by the tournament. 1. Each pair competes according to the predetermined match order; the team with the greater number of winning pairs wins. 2. Each pair competes in a Round-Robin or Tournament Bracket format; the team with the most wins is victorious.	

Rules	Detailed Rules
If win counts are equal, the team with the greater total flag count wins. If total flag counts are also equal, the outcome is decided by a Representative Tiebreaker. (Starting a Match) Article 9 — Competitors bow to each other at the Shushin's (Head Judge's) *Hajime* declaration, and the match begins. (Suspending and Resuming a Match) Article 10 — The judges declare *Chushi* (suspension); the Shushin declares resumption. (Request to Suspend a Match) Article 11 — When a competitor is unable to continue a match due to injury, accident, or similar cause, they may request Chushi. (End of Match) Article 12 — Competitors complete the designated techniques, return to the starting line, bow to each other, and await the judges' decision.	

Rules	Detailed Rules
Section 2 — Determining the Outcome (Determining the Outcome) Article 13 — The outcome is determined as follows. 1. The judgment is determined by the relative superiority of competitors in Ki-Jo-Tai-Ichi (Coordinated spirit, weapon and body) — in both technique and mental readiness — as expressed through correct Reiho (Etiquette) and proper conduct, with strong Kisei (Spirit and Vigor) and correct posture, grounded in accurate technique and swordsmanship. 2. All or part of the match techniques may be designated.	Detailed Rule 7 — Hantei is judged holistically based on the following criteria. 1. Strong Kisei (Spirit and Vigor) 2. Correct posture 3. Accuracy and appropriate force of strikes 4. Maai; Ma (Timing and Space) 5. Metsuke (Gaze) 6. Zanshin 7. Reiho (Etiquette) 8. Ki-Jo-Tai-Ichi (Coordinated spirit, weapon and body) 9. Jodo conducted in a martially coherent manner 10. Reference is made to the evaluation criteria for judging and grading set out in the AJKF Jodo Commentary.
Chapter 3 — Prohibited Acts Section 1 — Prohibited Conduct (Prohibited Substance Use) Article 14 — Using or possessing prohibited substances, or employing prohibited methods.	Detailed Rule 8 — For purposes of Rule 14, "prohibited substances" and "prohibited methods" are those listed on the current World Anti-Doping Agency (WADA) Prohibited List.

Rules	Detailed Rules
(Disrespectful Conduct) Article 15 — Engaging in disrespectful conduct toward judges or opponents. (Prohibited Acts) Article 16 — Engaging in conduct that disrupts the progress of a match or compromises its fairness. Section 2 — Penalties Article 17 — Any competitor found guilty of the prohibited acts set out in Articles 14, 15, or 16 is declared the loser; the opponent is awarded 3 Victory Flags, and the competitor is ordered to leave the court. The rights already earned by the expelled competitor are forfeited.	

Rules	Detailed Rules
Part 2 — Judging Chapter 1 — General Provisions (Composition of the Judging Panel) Article 18 — The judging panel consists of the Shinpancho (Tournament Director, for tournaments with two or more courts), the Shinpan Shunin (Presiding Judge), and the judges.	Anti-Doping Agency (WADA) Prohibited List.
(Shinpancho) Article 19 — The Shinpancho has the authority necessary to ensure fair matches are conducted.	Detailed Rule 9 — The duties of the Shinpancho are as follows. 1. Ensure strict application of the Rules and Detailed Rules. 2. Monitor the progress of matches. 3. Rule on formal protests. 4. Make rulings on matters not covered by the Rules and Detailed Rules, or on unforeseen incidents. Detailed Rule 10 — The Shinpancho's signal at the start of matches is as follows. 1. For single-court tournaments, when the first competitors stand at the Starting Lines, the Shinpancho stands, and the Shushin (Head Judge) opens the match with a declaration.

Rules	Detailed Rules
	2. For tournaments with two or more courts, when the first competitors stand at the Starting Lines and all courts are ready, the Shinpancho stands, signals with a whistle or similar, and the Shushin opens the match with a declaration.
(Shinpan Shunin) Article 20 — The Shinpan Shunin (Presiding Judge) assists the Shinpancho and holds the judging authority necessary for operations at their assigned court.	Detailed Rule 11 — The duties of the Shinpan Shunin are as follows. 1. Acts as the person responsible for their assigned court. 2. Ensures the Rules and Detailed Rules are properly applied. 3. When there is a rule violation or a formal protest, acts promptly and appropriately, and reports to the Shinpancho as necessary. 4. Has oversight of the judges at their assigned court.
(Judges) Article 21 — The judging panel should consist of one Shushin (Head Judge) and two Fukushin (Assistant Judges), in principle; all three hold equal authority in determining the outcome.	Detailed Rule 12 — The duties of judges are as follows. 1. Conduct their assigned match.

Rules	Detailed Rules
②. The Shushin holds overall authority over match operations and uses the judge's flags (hereinafter "the flags") to display judgments and make declarations. ③. The Fukushin use the flags to display judgments and assists the Shushin in operations. In emergencies, the Fukushin may also display and declare *Chushi* to suspend a match.	2. Make declarations and flag displays clearly. 3. Maintain unified decision-making among the judges. 4. Confirm the other judge's flag displays. 5. After each match, seek the observations of the Shinpan Shunin or Shinpancho as needed, and conduct a debrief with the other judges.
(Match Staff) Article 22 — For tournament operations, the following staff positions are established: Scoreboard Staff, Record Keeper, and Competitor Coordinator. Their composition and duties are set out in the Detailed Rules.	Detailed Rule 13 — Article 22 (Match Staff) lays out the composition and duties of the Match Staff as follows. 1. Scoreboard Staff consist of one supervisor and two or more staff members; they post the judges' results and inspect and verify the judges' flags. 2. Record Keepers consist of one supervisor and two or more staff members; they accurately record match results. 3. Competitor Coordinators consist of one supervisor and two or more staff members; they summon competitors and inspect equipment.

Rules	Detailed Rules
	Detailed Rule 14 — Judges wear kendo gi and hakama. However, tournaments may specify otherwise.
Chapter 2 — Judging Section 1 — Judging Matches (Determining the Outcome) Article 23 — The competitor with the greater number of Flags wins. (Judging Methods) Article 24 — Judges conduct matches as follows. 1. With the competitors standing at the Starting Lines, the Shushin starts the match with a *Hajime* declaration. 2. If a judge observes a rule violation, they suspend the match and convene a Gogi (deliberation) on the facts of the violation. 3. When determining the outcome, judges	

Rules	Detailed Rules
raise their flag simultaneously with the Shushin's *Hantei* declaration. Section 2 — Judging Actions (Injury or Accident) Article 25 — When a match cannot continue due to injury, accident, or similar cause, judges determine the cause and take the following action. 1. The decision on whether to continue is determined by the judges, informed by a doctor's assessment. The process should be completed within five minutes, in principle. 2. A competitor who refuses to continue despite having a minor injury that would not prevent participation is declared the loser. 3. When injury prevents a competitor from continuing, if the cause is a deliberate or negligent act of the other competitor, that competitor is declared the loser, but if the cause is unclear, the competitor who is unable to continue is declared the loser.	

Rules	Detailed Rules
4. A competitor who cannot continue due to an accident other than injury is declared the loser.	
(Withdrawal)	
Article 26 — A competitor who withdraws from a match is declared the loser and may not participate in any subsequent matches.	Detailed Rule 15 — Article 26 (Withdrawal) applies in the following cases. 1. The competitor has voluntarily withdrawn due to health or other reasons.
(Flags Already Earned by the Unable-to-Continue or Withdrawn Competitor)	
Article 27 — The winner in cases covered by Article 25 and Article 26 is awarded three Flags.	
(At-Fault Party's Rights Already Earned)	
Article 28 — The rights already earned by a competitor declared the loser as the at-fault party under Article 25, item 3 are not recognized.	
Section 3 — Deliberation and Making a Formal Protest	
(Deliberation)	
Article 29 — When judges need to call a Gogi (deliberation), they suspend the match and confer at the center of the court.	

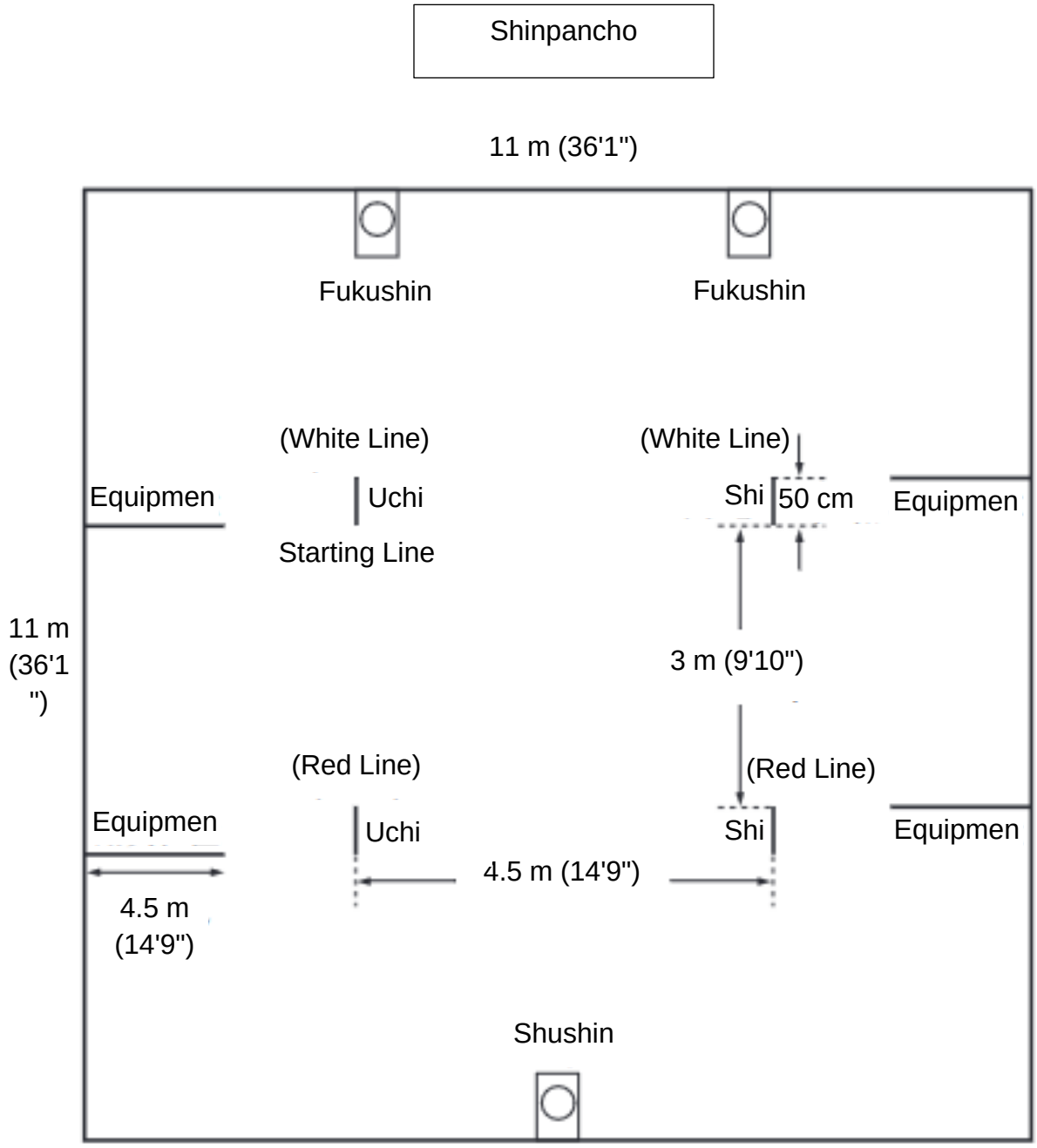
Rules	Detailed Rules
(Formal Protest) Article 30 — No one may file a formal protest against the judges' judgment. Article 31 — When a Team Captain questions the application of these Rules, they may file a formal protest with the Shinpan Shunin (Presiding Judge) or Shinpancho (Tournament Director) before the end of their competitor's embu. Chapter 3 — Declarations and Flag Displays (Declarations) Article 32 — Judges make declarations for match starts, suspensions, outcomes, deliberations, and similar situations; the procedures are set out in the Attached Table. (Flag Displays) Article 33 — Judges use their flags for suspensions, declaring match outcomes, deliberations, and similar situations according to the procedures set out in the Attached Table.	

Rules	Detailed Rules
Chapter 4 — Supplementary Provisions Article 34 — When a situation arises that is not covered by these Rules, the judges convene a Gogi (deliberation) and report to the Shinpan Shunin (Presiding Judge) or Shinpancho (Tournament Director) for resolution. Supplementary Provisions 1. When there are special circumstances due to the scale, content, or other aspects of a tournament, these Rules and Detailed Rules may be departed from, provided the purpose of the Rules and Detailed Rules is not undermined. 2. These Rules came into effect on April 1, 2012. 3. These Rules, as amended, came into effect on June 2, 2023.	1. These Detailed Rules came into effect on April 1, 2012. 2. These Detailed Rules, as amended, came into effect on June 2, 2023.

[Attached Table] — Judges' Declarations and Flag Displays

	Item	Declaration	Flag Display	Guidelines
Basic Posture			Hold both flags open with both hands, resting both fists on the knees.	FIG.1
Start	When starting a match	*Hajime*	Both flags at the sides of the body	Figure 2
Suspension	When suspending a match	*Yame*	Raise both flags directly overhead	Figure 6
Gogi (Deliberation)	When judges call a Gogi	*Gogi*	Raise both flags directly overhead with the right hand	Figure 7
Role Switch	When switching Shi and Uchi roles	*Shi-Uchi Kotai*	Both flags at the sides of the body	Figure 3
	After the switch	*Hajime*	Figure 3	Figure 3
Outcome Determination	When three red (white) flags are shown	*Hantei*, *Aka (Shiro) no Kachi*, *Shobu Ari*	Raise the flag from the side of the body diagonally upward	Figure 4
	When the Shushin raises the red (white) flag and both Fukushin raise the white (red) flag	*Hantei*, *Shiro (Aka) no Kachi*, *Shobu Ari*	Lower the red (white) flag to the side of the body and raise the white (red) flag diagonally upward.	Figure 4
	When one competitor performs the wrong designated technique (the competitor who made the error must still complete the embu)	*Gogi*, *Hantei*, *Aka (Shiro) no Kachi*, *Shobu Ari*	Raise both flags directly overhead with the right hand Raise the flag from the side of the body diagonally upward	Figure 7; Figure 14
	When both competitors fail to perform the designated techniques (both must complete the embu; outcome determined by the evaluation criteria)	*Gogi*, *Hantei*, *Aka (Shiro) no Kachi*, *Shobu Ari*	Raise both flags directly overhead with the right hand Raise the flag from the side of the body diagonally upward	Figure 7; Figure 14
	When an uncontested win is awarded	*Shobu Ari*	Raise the flag from the side of the body diagonally upward	Figure 5
	When a competitor is unable to continue	*Shobu Ari*	Raise the flag from the side of the body diagonally upward	Figure 5
	When a prohibited substance is used or possessed, or disrespectful conduct occurs	*Yame* *Gogi* *Hantei*, *Aka (Shiro) no Kachi*, *Shobu Ari*	Raise both flags directly overhead Raise both flags directly overhead with the right hand Raise the flag from the side of the body diagonally upward	Figure 6 Figure 7 Figure 5
Injury, Accident, or Withdrawal	When a match cannot continue due to injury, accident, withdrawal, or similar cause	*Shobu Ari*	Raise the flag from the side of the body diagonally upward	Figure 5

Figure 1: Court (Standards)

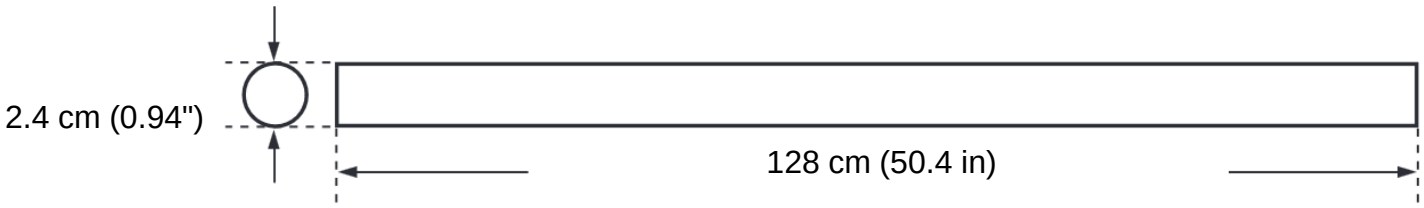


* The boundary of the court may be marked with a line.

* Depending on venue conditions, the size of the court may be reduced as appropriate.

Figure 2: Equipment

Jo



Tachi (Bokuto)

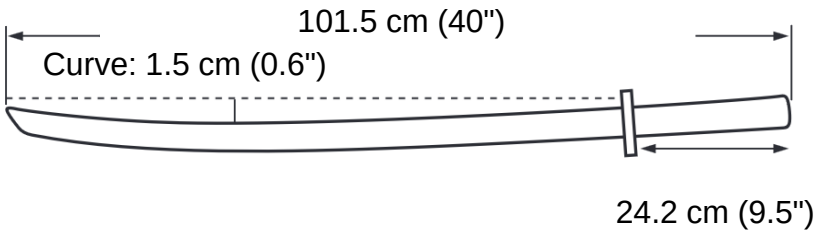


Figure 3: Competitor's Nafuda (Name Badge)

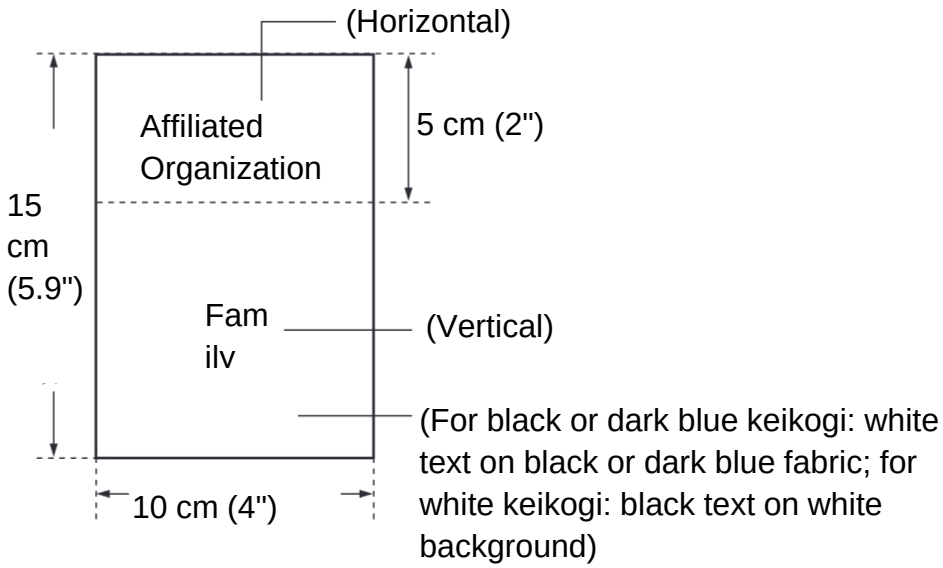
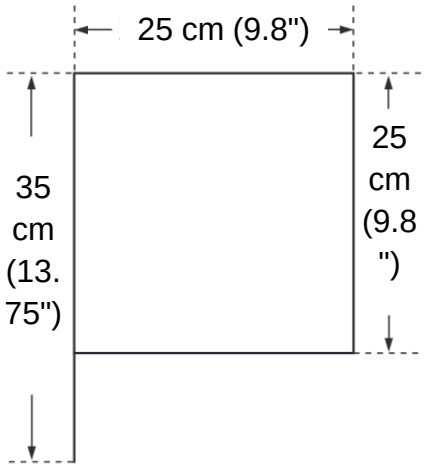
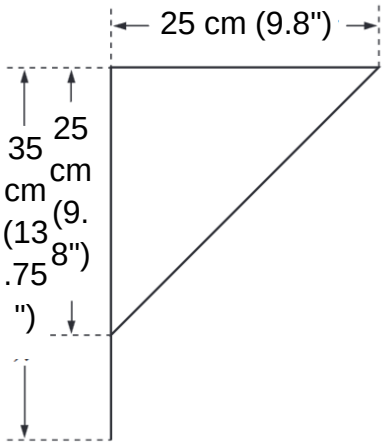


Figure 4: Shinpan-ki (Judge's Flag) Specifications

· Shinpan-ki (red/white)



· Captain's flag (red)



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Attachment 1 Guidelines for Holding and Judging Jodo Matches

July 1, 1997

Partially revised on June 2, 2023

All Japan Kendo Federation

Contestant Guidelines	Judge Guidelines
Entering the Court	
1. The competitor waits at their court until called upon and then enters the court from the waiting area, and proceeds to the starting line.	1. When the judges (shinpan) enter, they first line up with flags held in their right hand, and the head judge (shushin) takes the center position. After bowing to shomen, they move to their designated positions (see Figure 1 from Procedures for moving and switching out judges). Holding Flags and Switching Out Judges 1. Judges hold their flags unrolled on their knees. The head judge holds the red flag on their right side and white flag on their left while the assistant judges (fukushin) hold the white flag on their right side and red flag on their left. 2. The guidelines for switching out judges are as follows (see Figures 3 to 6 from Procedures for moving and switching out judges). - Moving and switching out the head judge and assistant judges - (1) The judges move to their designated position and switch roles without rolling up their flags (see Figure 3). - Switching judges in place - (2) Each judge rolls up both of their flags, bows with their replacement (sogo ni rei), and switches roles (see Figure 4).

Contestant Guidelines	Judge Guidelines
	- One judge switching out after a rotation - (3) Each judge moves to their designated position, and the judge who has completed their turn as head judge rolls up both flags and bows with their replacement (see Figure 5). - Judges switching out after completing their rotation - (4) The judge who has completed their rotation rolls up both flags, lines up, and switches with the next judge (see Figure 6). 3. When all judges switch out together, they line up with the head judge taking the center position, bow to shomen and exit.
Bowing to shomen	
1. In the following cases, the competitor bows to shomen in response to the command given by the head judge. (1) At the beginning of the first match and at the beginning and end of the final match. (2) If the tournament spans two or more days, at the beginning of the first match, at the end of the last match, and at the beginning and end of the final match. (3) Bow to shomen from the starting line position.	1. Judges bow to shomen in the following cases (1) At the beginning of the first match and at the beginning and end of the final match. (2) If the tournament spans two or more days, at the beginning of the first match, at the end of the last match, and at the beginning and end of the final match. (3) Immediately after the judges and competitors have taken their positions, the head judge calls for the bow to shomen (see Figure 1 from Positions before and after a match)

Contestant Guidelines	Judge Guidelines
Bowing to each other (Sogo no rei)	
1. The competitors bow to each other in the following manner. (1) At the Shushin's *Hajime* declaration, competitors bow to each other and begin the match. (2) The competitors finish performing the pre-selected kata, return to the starting line, bow to each other (sogo ni rei), and wait for the determination of the judges.	
Starting a Match	
1. Before beginning the match, Uchi waits in Sageto and Shi waits in Tsune no Kamae at the starting line. In response to the head judge's callout, Uchi remains in Sageto while Jo transitions to Sagejo and they bow to each other (sogo no rei). Then Uchi transitions to Keito and Shi transitions to Tsune no Kamae and the match begins.	1. The head judge handles the first match and final match as follows. (1) For single-court tournaments, when the first match competitors or final match competitors stand at the starting line – Uchi in Taito Shisei, Shi in Tsune no Kamae – the Shinpancho (Tournament Director) stands and the Shushin starts the match with a declaration. (2) For tournaments with two or more courts, when the first match competitors or final match competitors stand at the starting line – Uchi in Taito Shisei, Shi in Tsune no Kamae – and all courts are ready, the Shinpancho stands, signals with a whistle or similar, and the Shushin starts the match with a declaration (Flag Display Guide, Figure 2).

Contestant Guidelines	Judge Guidelines
Request to Suspend a Match	
1. A competitor requests the suspension of a match by raising their hand, declaring this to Shushin, and immediately stating their reason.	1. If there is a request from a competitor to discontinue the match, the Shushin immediately stops the match and asks what the reason is for the request (Article 11 of the Rules for Holding and Judging Matches). 2. If the Shushin determines that the request for suspension set forth in the preceding paragraph is unreasonable, the judges enter into a Gogi (Deliberation).
Suspension	
1. When a judge declares *Yame*, competitors immediately suspend the match. Uchi returns to the starting line in Kamae wo Toita Shisei (see the Jodo Manual); Shi returns and stands in Tsune no Kamae and awaits the Shushin's declaration or instructions.	1. Judges declare Chushi (Suspension) in the following cases. (1) A rule violation (2) Injury or accident (3) Prevention of danger (4) A formal protest (5) A Gogi (deliberation) 2. When declaring Chushi, judges proceed as follows.

Contestant Guidelines	Judge Guidelines
	(1) When a competitor requests Chushi, the Shushin immediately declares Chushi and displays both flags simultaneously (Flag Display Guide, Figure 6). (2) When a Fukushin declares Chushi, the Shushin immediately declares Chushi and displays both flags simultaneously (Flag Display Guide, Figure 6).
Gogi (Deliberation)	
1. When the Shushin declares a Gogi, competitors suspend the match. Uchi returns to the starting line and stands in Kamae wo Toita Shisei; Shi returns to the starting line and stands in Tsune no Kamae and they wait.	1. Judges call a Gogi in the following cases. (1) Failure to perform the designated techniques (2) A prohibited act (3) A Team Captain's formal protest 2. Judges conduct a Gogi as follows. (1) Declare a Gogi and display both flags simultaneously (Flag Display Guide, Figure 7). Have Uchi return to the starting line and stand in Kamae wo Toita Shisei and Shi return to the starting line and stand in Tsune no Kamae and wait. (2) When a Fukushin declares *Yame* and requests a Gogi, the Shushin immediately suspends the match and declares a Gogi, displaying both flags simultaneously (Flag Display Guide, Figure 6 → Figure 7).

Contestant Guidelines	Judge Guidelines
	(3) When the need for a Gogi arises mid-match, declare Chushi and conduct the Gogi following procedures (1) and (2). However, a Gogi for a failure to perform the designated techniques must be held immediately before judgment is declared.
Resumption	
1. When resuming after a Chushi, competitors remain standing at the starting line and resume the match at the Shushin's declaration.	1. When resuming after a Chushi, the Shushin follows the match-start procedure (Flag Display Guide, Figure 2).
Formal Protest	
1. When the Team Captain files a formal protest, competitors wait following the Gogi procedure.	1. When a formal protest is filed, judges proceed as follows. (1) Judges immediately suspend the match (Flag Display Guide, Figure 6). (2) The Shinpan Shunin or Shinpancho directs the judges to deliberate the point of contention.

Contestant Guidelines	Judge Guidelines
	(3) The Shinpan Shunin or Shinpancho communicates the outcome to the Team Captain. (4) The Shushin resumes the match (Flag Display Guide, Figure 2).
Declaring the Outcome	
1. Competitors finish the embu, return to the starting lines, and bow to each other. Uchi then awaits the judgment in Taito Shisei; Shi awaits in Tsune no Kamae.	1. To determine the outcome, judges raise their flag for the side they judge to be the winner, simultaneously with the Shushin's *Hantei* declaration (Flag Display Guide, Figure 4). Judges are not permitted to declare a draw or abstain from voting.
Unable to Continue	
1. When the outcome is determined by a competitor being unable to continue, competitors stand at the starting line, Uchi in Taito Shisei, Shi in Tsune no Kamae, and Shushin declares the outcome.	1. When declaring an outcome due to inability to continue, the Shushin declares and raises both flags for the winning side simultaneously (Flag Display Guide, Figure 5).
Uncontested Win	
1. When a competitor receives a declaration of uncontested win, they stand at the starting line following match procedure, Uchi in Taito Shisei, Shi in Tsune no Kamae, receive the Shushin's declaration, and return to position.	1. The Shushin declares and displays the flags for the winning side simultaneously (Flag Display Guide, Figure 5).

Contestant Guidelines	Judge Guidelines
Conclusion	
1. When the match concludes, competitors stand at the starting line. Uchi moves from Keito Shisei to Taito Shisei; Shi moves from Tsune no Kamae to Sagejo. They bow to each other, then exit the court after the Shushin's declaration.	1. All judges display their flag simultaneously with the Shushin's declaration (Flag Display Guide, Figure 4), after the embu has concluded, the competitors have bowed to each other, and they are standing at the starting line, Uchi in Taito Shisei, Shi in Tsune no Kamae. 2. When the match concludes, judges roll up both flags with the white flag inside and the red flag outside, hold the Shinpan-ki (Judge's Flag) in the right hand, line up with the Shushin in the center, bow to shomen, and exit (Judge Rotation Guide, Figure 6).
Other Guidelines	
1. Competitors' uniforms must be clean and free of fraying or tears. 2. Competitors must not enter the court until the judges have rotated and taken their positions. 3. Incoming competitors advance from the waiting area and enter the court when the preceding competitors leave the starting line and exit (Figure 1: Pre- and Post-Match Lineup).	1. Before the match, judges check that competitors' uniforms (keikogi, hakama, and Nafuda (Name Badge)) are appropriate. 2. If a competitor engages in or attempts to engage in inappropriate conduct at the competitor's bench or elsewhere after the match, judges must firmly instruct them.

Contestant Guidelines	Judge Guidelines
4. Team Captains and other competitors must not give signals or call out encouragement to competitors during a match.	3. Support staff must coordinate closely in advance under the Shinpan Shunin or Shinpancho to ensure smooth task execution, then carry out their duties promptly and accurately. 4. Scoreboard Staff check and confirm the Shinpan-ki.

Figure 1: Lineup Method Before and

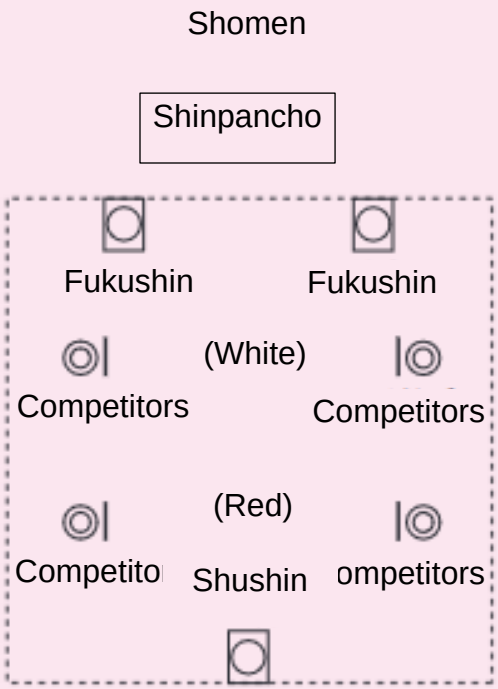


Figure 1: Judges' Entry and Lineup

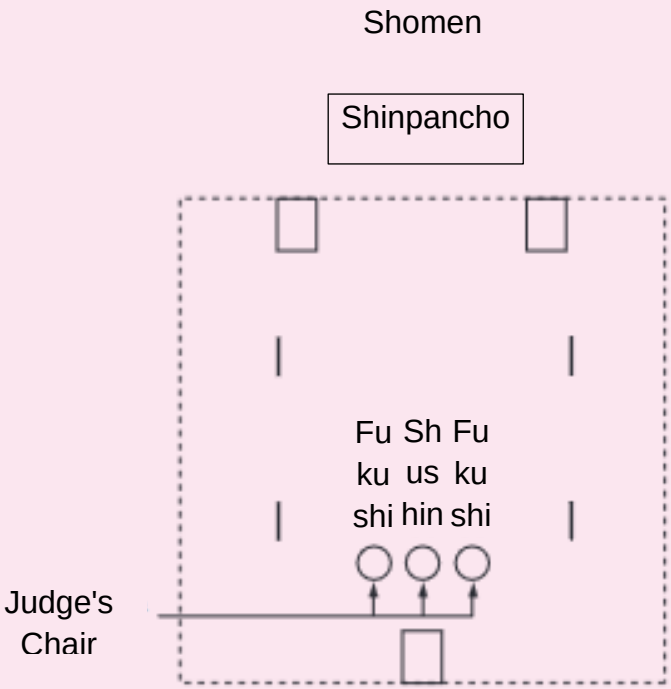


Figure 2: Judges' Designated Positions

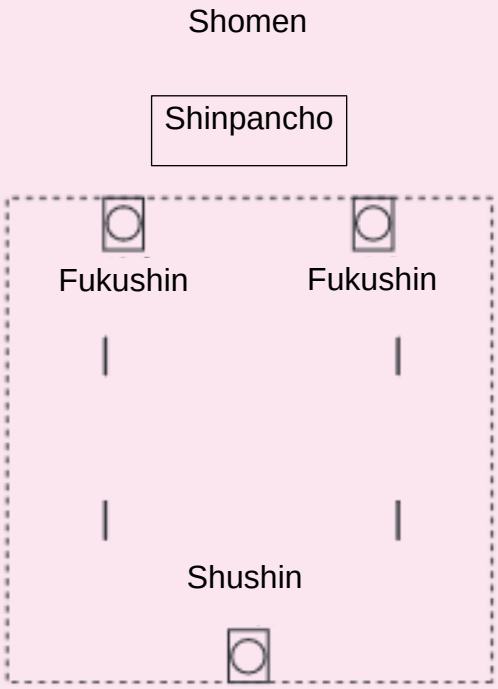


Figure 3: Shushin and Fukushin

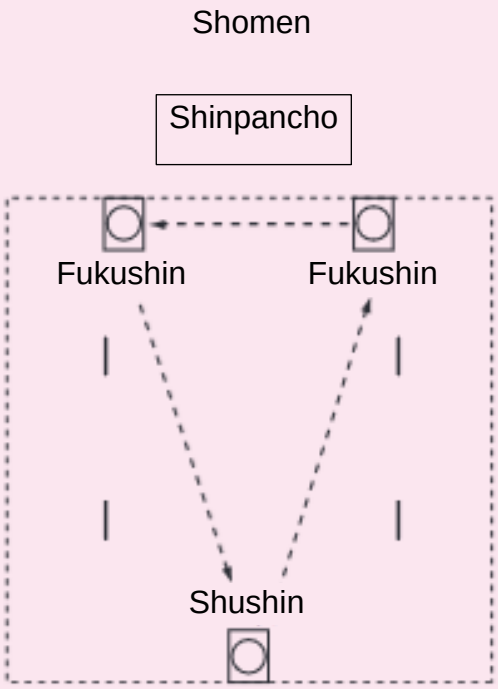


Figure 4: On-the-Spot Judge Rotation

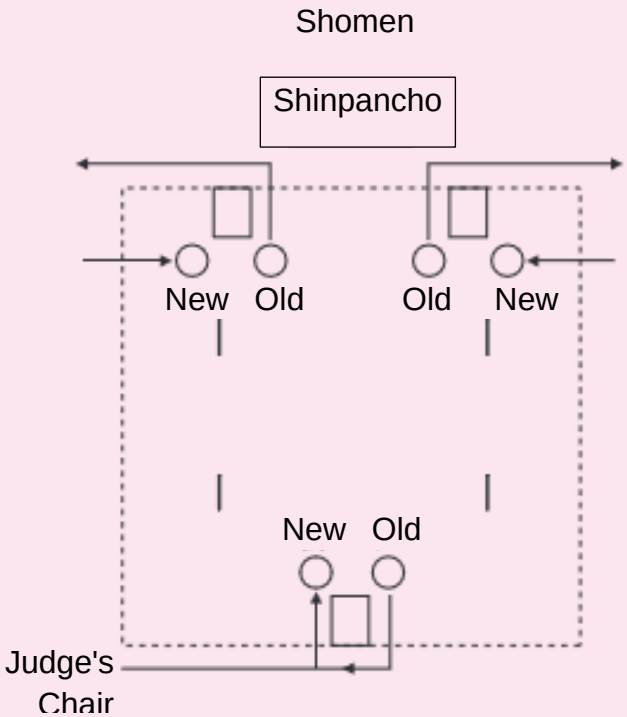


Figure 5: Judges Rotate by Moving

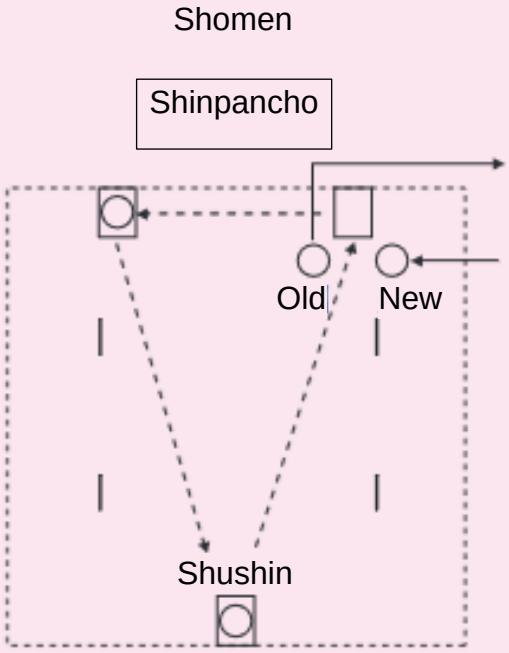
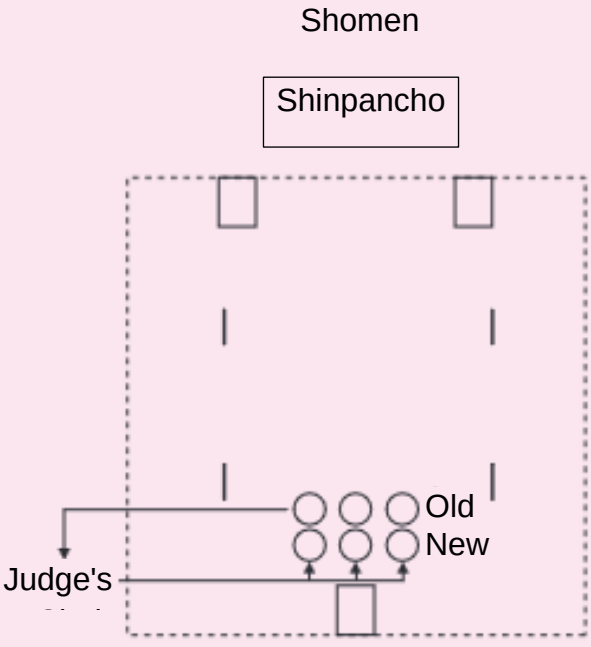
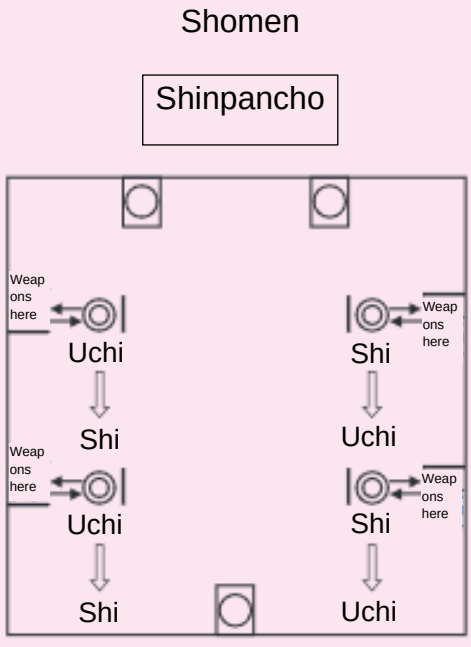


Figure 6: Rotation of Outgoing Judges

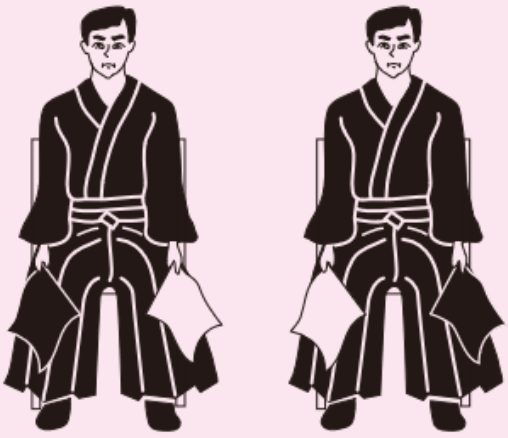


Competitor Role Exchange Guide



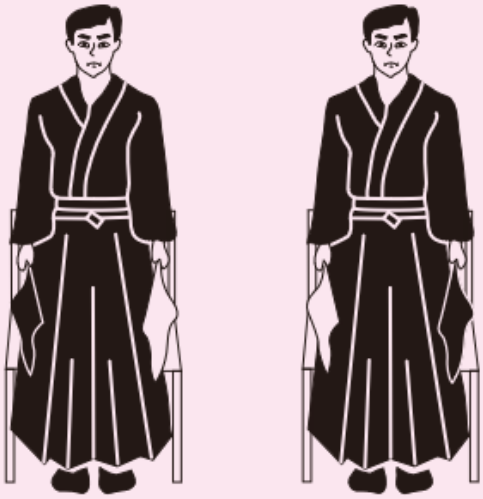
Procedure: At the signal for the Shi/Uchi role exchange, move back to the weapon position, exchange weapons, and return to the starting line.

Figure 1: Basic Posture
On their lap, the Shushin holds the red flag to the right and the white flag to the left (the Fukushin holds the red flag to the left and the white flag to the right).
Judges sit in a chair with approximately 30 centimeters between their knees.



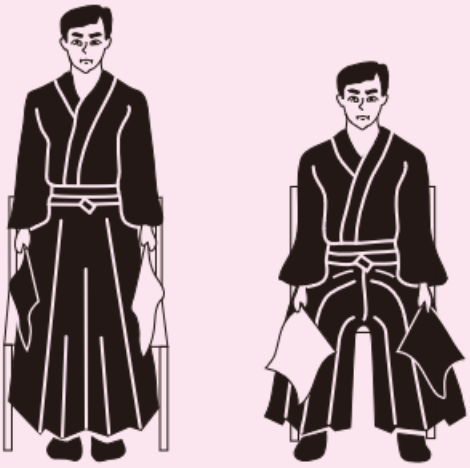
(Shushin) (Fukushin)

Figure 2: At the declaration to start or resume the match
Both the Shushin and Fukushin stand.



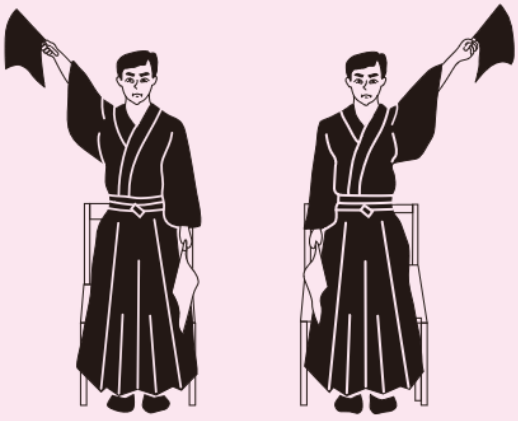
(Shushin) (Fukushin)

Figure 3: At the Shi/Uchi Role Exchange
The Shushin stands; the Fukushin remains seated.



(Shushin) (Fukushin)

Figure 4: Determining the Outcome (Flag Display for the Side Judged the Winner)
Judges stand and raise their flag diagonally upward.
Both the Shushin and Fukushin stand.

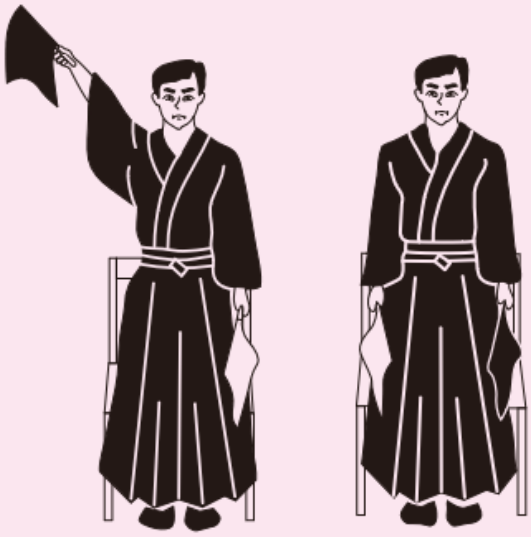


(Shushin) (Fukushin)

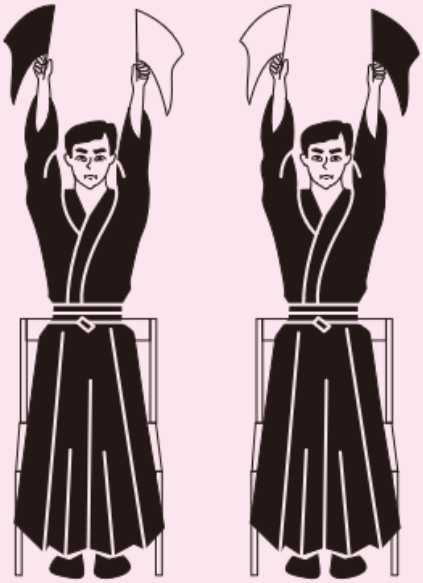
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Figure 5: Determining the Outcome (At the Declaration of an Uncontested Win, etc.)
The Shushin stands and raises their flag from the side of the body diagonally upward.
The Fukushin stands with both flags at the sides of the body.

Figure 6: At Chushi
Judges stand and raise both flags straight up.



(Shushin) (Fukushin)



(Shushin) (Fukushin)

Figure 7: Gogi (Deliberations)
The judge stands, holds both flags in the right hand, and raises them straight up.

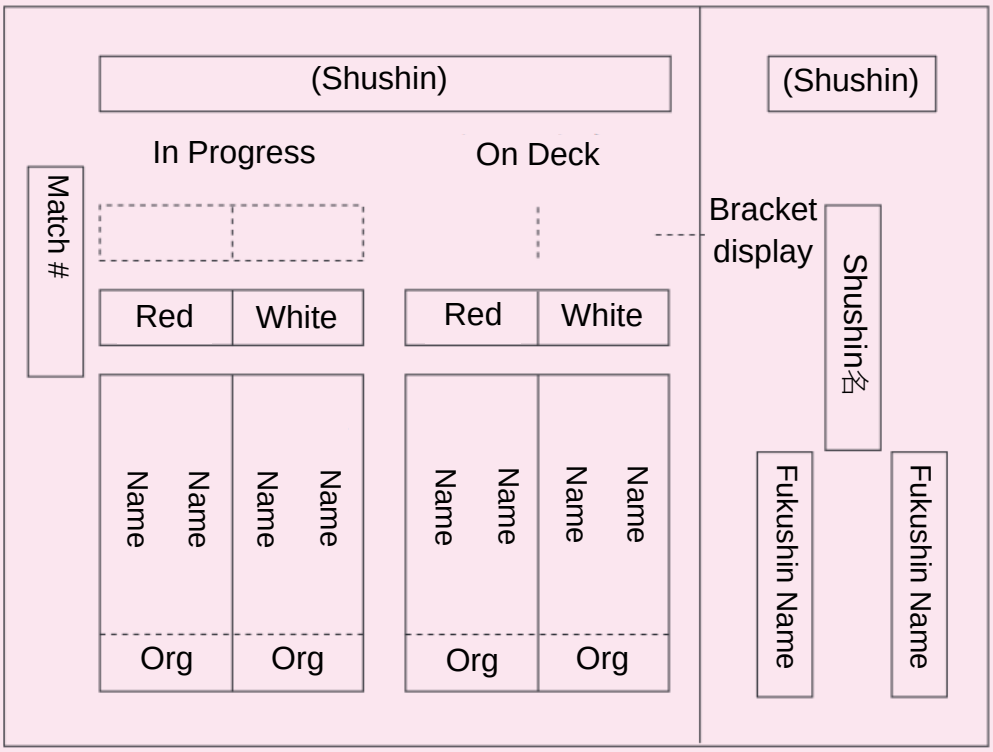


Scoreboard Guide

1. Accurately display match results on the scoreboard based on the Shushin's declarations and flags displayed by the judges.

2. The method for displaying the judges' names and competitors' names (or team names) on the scoreboard is as shown in Figure 1.

Figure 1: Scoreboard and Display Method



Supplementary Provision: These Guidelines came into force on July 1, 1997.

Supplementary Provision: These partially revised Guidelines came into force on August 1, 2003.

Supplementary Provision: These partially revised Guidelines came into effect on June 2, 2023.

Attachment 2 Amendments to the Jodo Shiai and Shinpan Regulations and Key Operational Considerations

July 1, 1997

All Japan Kendo Federation

Amendments to the Jodo Shiai and Shinpan Regulations and Key Operational Considerations

(Purpose of These Regulations)

Article 1.

Clarified that the purpose of the match and adjudication regulations is conducting matches with integrity and fairness and appropriate and impartial adjudication.

(Court)

Article 2

Specified that the floor be wooden flooring whenever possible.

Added the standard distances between the starting lines and between the red and white starting lines as a diagram.

Added a diagram of the standard dimensions of a court.

(Equipment)

Article 3.

Added an equipment diagram.

(Uniform)

Article 4

Specified competitors' uniforms as keikogi and hakama.

Stipulated the wearing of a Nafuda (Name Badge) by competitors.

Clarified the specifications for the Shinpan-ki (Judge's Flag) and other.

(Competitor Composition)

Article 5.

Clarified the composition of competitors.

(Individual Match)

Article 7

Clarified the method for determining the outcome of individual matches.

(Team Match)

Article 8.

Clarified the method for determining the outcome of team matches.

(Start of Match)

Article 9

Clarified that the Shushin's declaration begins the match.

(Suspension and Resumption of Match)

Article 10

Clarified the procedures for suspension and resumption.

(Request to Suspend the Match)

Article 11

An improper suspension request is subject to a Gogi.

(Judging the Outcome)

Article 13

Specified the criteria for determining the outcome and set out the judgment criteria in the Detailed Rules.

(Use of Prohibited Substances)

Article 14.

Added the use of prohibited substances to the list of prohibited acts. Substances are defined in the Detailed Rules.

(Penalties)

Article 17.

Specified that the prohibited acts under Articles 14, 15, and 16 are conduct unbecoming of a jodo practitioner and must be dealt with strictly.

(Composition of Judges)

Article 18.

Specified the composition of judges.

(Shinpancho)

Article 19

Listed the Shinpancho's duties with specific examples in the Detailed Rules.

Clarified that "Ruling" in Detailed Rule 9, Item 3 refers to the authority to make a final discretionary decision on matters that cannot be resolved by the three judges alone.

(Shinpan Shunin)

Article 20.

Described the Shinpan Shunin's duties with specific examples in the Detailed Rules.

(Judges)

Article 21.

Specified that a three-judge panel is the standard and that all judges hold equal authority for judgments, in principle.

Described the judges' duties with specific examples in the Detailed Rules.

(Support Staff)

Article 22.

Consolidated support staff under a single category, replacing separate regulations for each individual role.

Built in flexibility to allow operational methods to adapt to the scale and nature of each tournament.

Moved duties to the Detailed Rules so that organizers can manage them at their own discretion.

Clarified judges' uniforms in Detailed Rule 14.

(Declaring the Outcome)

Article 23

Clarified the method for declaring the outcome.

(Judging Method)

Article 24

Clarified the adjudication procedures from match start through suspension to judgment.

(Injury or Accident)

Article 25

Moved provisions for what judges must do in cases of injury or accident from the match regulations to the adjudication regulations as they relate to match operations.

Specified that the process of determining whether a match can continue should be completed within five minutes, in principle.

(Withdrawal)

Article 26

Clarified the handling of withdrawal in the supplementary rules.

(Flags Won Before Withdrawal or Inability to Continue)

Article 27.

Clarified the number of Flags awarded to the winner when a competitor is unable to continue due to injury or accident, or withdrawal.

(At-Fault Party's Rights Already Earned)

Article 28.

Clarified the treatment of the rights already earned by an at-fault competitor declared the loser.

(Gogi)

Article 29.

Clarified the procedures for a judges' Gogi (deliberation).

(Formal Protest)

Article 30.

Specified that formal protests against any judge's judgment are not permitted regardless of the grounds.

Article 31

Clarified that a Team Captain may file a formal protest when there is clear suspicion of a manifest violation in the application of these regulations.

(Declaration)

Article 32

Collated declarations and flag displays in the Attached Table for clarity.

(Flag Display)

Article 33

Clarified the flag display procedures for judges from the start through the conclusion of the match.

(Supplementary Provision)

Article 34

Appended in consideration of special circumstances such as the scale and nature of the tournament.

Attachment 1: Guidelines for Holding and Judging Jodo Matches

1. Established these Guidelines as a general AJKF standard for tournaments, not intended to restrict individual tournaments from setting their own guidelines.

2. Specified that the judges for the first match enter with the flags; judges do not exchange flags at subsequent rotations.

3. Clarified the procedures for bowing to shomen and bowing to each other.

4. Eliminated draws; judges must raise their flag for one side or the other.

Jodo Tournament Judge Roles

Source: 杖道試合・審判規則 (AJKF Jodo Match and Judging Rules, revised June 2, 2023)

Overview

Every jodo tournament has four distinct officiating roles. They are always different people, each occupying a defined position in a clear hierarchy. The hierarchy is scope-based: each level has authority over a wider area than the one below it.

Fukushin → Shushin → Shinpan Shunin → Shinpancho

1. Shinpancho (審判長) — Chief Judge

The top of the officiating hierarchy. Sits at the front of the court (正面), facing the action. Does not hold flags or call individual matches. Their authority is tournament-wide.

- Oversees strict application of the rules throughout the tournament
- Monitors match flow across all courts
- Rules on formal appeals (異議の申し立て) — the final word. The rules commentary clarifies this is a discretionary ruling on high-level matters the three floor judges cannot resolve.
- Handles anything not covered by the rules: accidents, unforeseen situations, edge cases
- Formally signals the start of the first match and the finals (stands up; uses a whistle if multiple courts are running)

2. Shinpan Shunin (審判主任) — Court Supervisor

Only exists at tournaments with two or more courts running simultaneously. One Shinpan Shunin is assigned per court. Does not hold flags or call individual matches.

- Is the responsible party (責任者) for their assigned court
- Monitors that the three floor judges are applying the rules correctly
- When a violation or protest arises, handles it promptly and reports to the Shinpancho as needed
- Oversees and manages the three floor judges on that court

The Shinpan Shunin is the middle layer — a court manager who bridges the floor judges and the Chief Judge.

3. Shushin (主審) — Presiding Floor Judge

One of the three floor judges. The "voice" of the panel — the only one who speaks. Has authority over all aspects of match management (全般に関する権限). Positioned at the bottom of the court, near the entrance side.

- Makes all verbal announcements: "Hajime" (start), "Yame" (stop), "Hantei" (judgment), "Gogi" (deliberation), "Shi/Uchi kotai" (role swap), etc.
- Holds flags and displays results in coordination with the Fukushin
- Controls match flow: starts, stops, restarts
- Signals bow to the front (正面への礼) when required
- Checks competitors' attire before the match begins

Note: Despite having operational authority, the Shushin's vote on who wins counts the same as each Fukushin's vote. Judgment authority is equal among all three floor judges.

4. Fukushin (副審) — Assistant Floor Judges ×2

The other two of the three floor judges. Positioned on the left and right sides of the court. Normally silent — they communicate only through flag display.

- Hold flags and display judgments in sync with the Shushin's "Hantei" call
- Assist the Shushin in match operations
- Emergency exception: A Fukushin can call "Yame" and signal a stop independently if the situation is urgent

Comparison Table

Role	Judges technique?	Speaks?	Holds flags?	Rules on appeals?
Shinpancho	No	Signals start only	No	Yes — final authority
Shinpan Shunin	No	Handles protests only	No	Refers to Shinpancho
Shushin	Yes (equal vote)	Yes — all calls	Yes	No
Fukushin ×2	Yes (equal vote)	Emergency only	Yes	No

Key Points

- All four roles are always different people. The rules place them in distinct physical positions and there is no provision for combining roles.
- The Shushin and both Fukushin have exactly equal voting weight on who wins (Article 21 explicitly states 同等の権限 — equal authority). A 2–1 split stands regardless of which judge is in the minority.
- The Shinpan Shunin role only exists when there are two or more courts. At a single-court tournament, the Shinpancho supervises the floor judges directly.

July 2023